The Quiet Exclusion of Independent Researchers

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Abstract

Scientific exclusion is typically understood as the result of explicit rejection. However, exclusion can occur without any decision. This paper introduces the concept of quiet exclusion to describe situations in which access is restricted through entry barriers, delays, non-response, or non-progressive evaluation processes. No decision is made, yet participation does not occur. Quiet exclusion is characterized by the absence of clear evaluative signals, neither acceptance nor rejection, producing an indeterminate state that prevents resolution. Drawing on documented cases across platforms and journal workflows, including Zenodo, ResearchGate, arXiv, and submission systems, the analysis shows that exclusion can arise at multiple stages, from registration to evaluation. These mechanisms differ in form but converge in outcome: they prevent participation without producing an identifiable rejection event. The paper proposes a process-based model of access defined by entry, progression, and completion. Within this framework, exclusion occurs whenever any component fails, even in the absence of explicit denial. This perspective reframes openness not as a binary condition, but as a process. In a functionally open system, progression should be independent of affiliation signals. If it is not, openness exists at the level of form but not at the level of process. From this perspective, explicitly stating that not all submissions are evaluated would clarify evaluative signals and prevent non-response from being misinterpreted as a judgment of quality.

Introduction

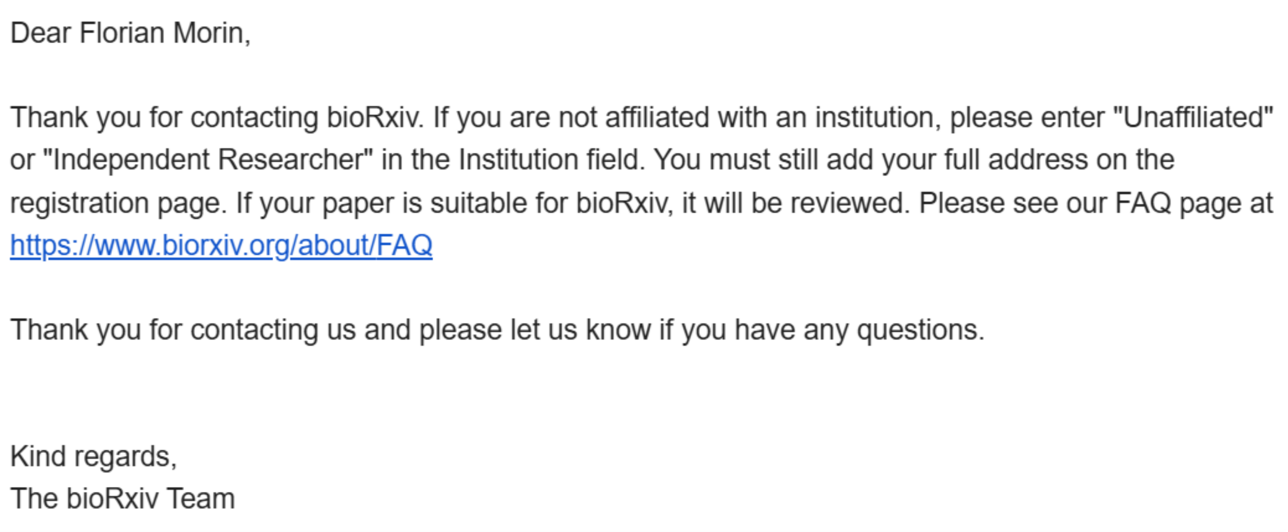
Scientific exclusion is typically understood as explicit rejection. However, exclusion can occur without any decision. Systems may appear open and accessible, yet participation does not occur. No decision is issued. The process remains incomplete. This paper defines this mechanism as quiet exclusion.

Quiet exclusion refers to situations in which independent researchers are unable to enter or progress within scientific systems, not through formal denial, but through opaque validation procedures, prolonged non-response, or implicit requirements such as institutional affiliation.

In such cases, affiliation does not function as an explicit gate, but as a background condition that modulates access. The individual is neither accepted nor rejected, but remains suspended in a procedural state without resolution.
Unlike explicit gatekeeping, quiet exclusion produces no clear decision, no appeal pathway, and minimal visibility. As a result, it is difficult to detect, contest, or quantify. Prior work has shown that scientific evaluation processes can involve opacity and informal criteria (Smith, 2006; Tennant et al., 2017), but these accounts primarily focus on decisions. Quiet exclusion instead operates through the absence of decision.
The present study develops this framework through documented cases involving Zenodo, ResearchGate, arXiv, and the journal Human Factors. Across these cases, exclusion does not arise as a single identifiable event, but as a distributed process unfolding across registration systems, validation procedures, editorial workflows, and legitimacy heuristics. Rather than being explicitly enacted, it emerges from the accumulation of small procedural frictions that prevent progression toward evaluation. Participation is initiated, but does not reach completion.
These mechanisms are sustained by ordinary operational dynamics: limited support responsiveness, implicit norms of legitimacy, and weak accountability in validation processes. The interaction between automated systems and human non-response stabilizes a form of exclusion that is decentralized, persistent, and difficult to attribute to any single actor (Pasquale, 2015; Gillespie, 2014).
The implications extend beyond individual cases. By selectively constraining participation without explicit rejection, quiet exclusion may introduce systematic biases in knowledge production, particularly affecting non-institutional researchers. These biases emerge not through visible decisions, but through low-visibility constraints embedded in access, validation, and support processes (Mirowski, 2018; Fecher & Friesike, 2014).
Quiet exclusion challenges the assumption that open systems are inherently accessible. A system may allow entry in principle, yet fail to sustain progression or reach completion in practice. In such cases, openness exists at the level of form, but not at the level of process.

Formal Openness vs. Process-Level Constraints

Official platform responses explicitly affirm that independent researchers are permitted to submit manuscripts as shown in Figure 1.



Dear Florian Morin,

Thank you for contacting bioRxiv. If you are not affiliated with an institution, please enter "Unaffiliated" or "Independent Researcher" in the Institution field. You must still add your full address on the registration page. If your paper is suitable for bioRxiv, it will be reviewed. Please see our FAQ page at https://www.biorxiv.org/about/FAQ

Thank you for contacting us and please let us know if you have any questions.

Kind regards,
The bioRxiv Team

Figure 1. Official response from bioRxiv confirming that independent researchers are allowed to submit manuscripts, indicating formal openness at the policy level.

This confirms formal openness at the policy level. However, effective access may still be constrained in practice.

Implicit Filtering of Independent Profiles

Single-author papers using non-institutional email addresses (e.g., @gmail) are not formally prohibited in scientific publishing. However, they remain extremely rare among accepted outputs, particularly in established journals. This discrepancy suggests that exclusion does not operate through explicit rules, but through implicit filtering mechanisms. Submissions lacking institutional affiliation or collaborative authorship may be perceived as higher-risk, more difficult to evaluate, or harder to situate within existing research networks. As a result, while such profiles are theoretically permitted, they are effectively filtered in practice. This produces a form of exclusion that is not declared, but emerges from routine evaluation heuristics. When evaluation processes are opaque, the absence of response can be misinterpreted as a negative assessment, effectively transforming non-processing into perceived judgment.

The model predicts that progression probability is not solely a function of content quality, but is modulated by initial legitimacy signals. In particular, submissions associated with non-institutional email domains and independent authorship are expected to exhibit reduced transition rates from entry to progression stages. This prediction can be tested using controlled submission designs in which identical manuscripts are submitted under different identity conditions (institutional vs independent, institutional vs personal email), and progression outcomes are compared. Within the process model **(Access = Entry × Progression × Completion × Persistence)**, this effect specifically predicts a modulation of the progression component by legitimacy signals, independent of content.

Methodological note

This paper adopts a case-based analytical approach to examine access processes in open science platforms. The analysis draws on three complementary types of material:
Documented first-person interactions: records of submission attempts, platform responses, and account actions, including rejection messages, automated classifications, support requests, and instances of non-response.

Platform-level observable structures: publicly accessible rules, submission conditions, and interface-level constraints shaping entry, evaluation, and dissemination.

Process-level interpretation: reconstruction of access as a sequence of stages (entry, progression, completion), used to identify where and how participation is interrupted.

The objective is not to evaluate individual decisions, but to characterize recurring process patterns that can produce exclusion without explicit rejection. The case studies are not intended to be exhaustive or statistically representative. Rather, they function as analytical probes to identify recurrent mechanisms across heterogeneous contextes. Where available, supporting materials (e.g., screenshots, structured records) are included to document specific interactions. These materials are illustrative and do not imply general prevalence. By focusing on process rather than isolated decisions, this approach identifies low-visibility barriers emerging from the structure and dynamics of access systems.

Case Study 1. Human Factors Journal Submission

(Response Loop Without Progression)

This case illustrates a failure at the progression stage of the access process. Entry is successful, but no transition occurs toward evaluation or completion. The system returns the manuscript after resubmission, but does not progress toward evaluation as shown in Figure 2. No reviewers are assigned, and no scores are submitted, see Figure 3.

Dear Dr. Morin:

Your manuscript, HF-26-9943, entitled ‘Ease, A threshold model of positive engagement under reduced evaluative monitoring’ has been unsubmitted from Human Factors : The Journal of the Hu Factors and Ergonomics Society.

It has been unsubmitted because the following changes are required:

- References - The references need to be in the APA style i.e., APA with indent hanging and in alphabetical order.

Figure 2. The system returns the manuscript repeatedly without progressing toward evaluation.

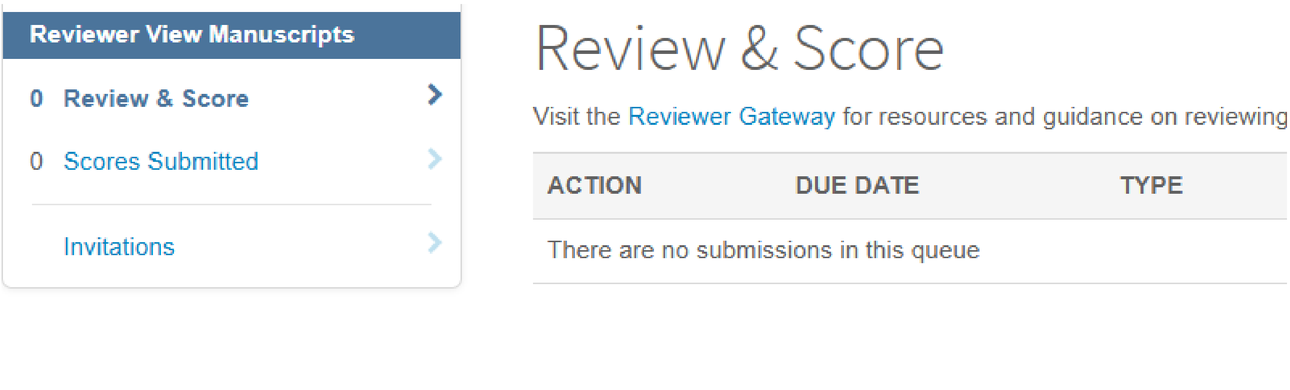


Figure 3. No reviewers assigned and no scores submitted, indicating no progression to peer review.

Interaction is maintained, but no state transition occurs. In one of the platform menus, the category “independent researcher” remains explicitly displayed, including three months after the observed access restrictions, as shown in Figure 4. The interface signals openness, but progression remains blocked.

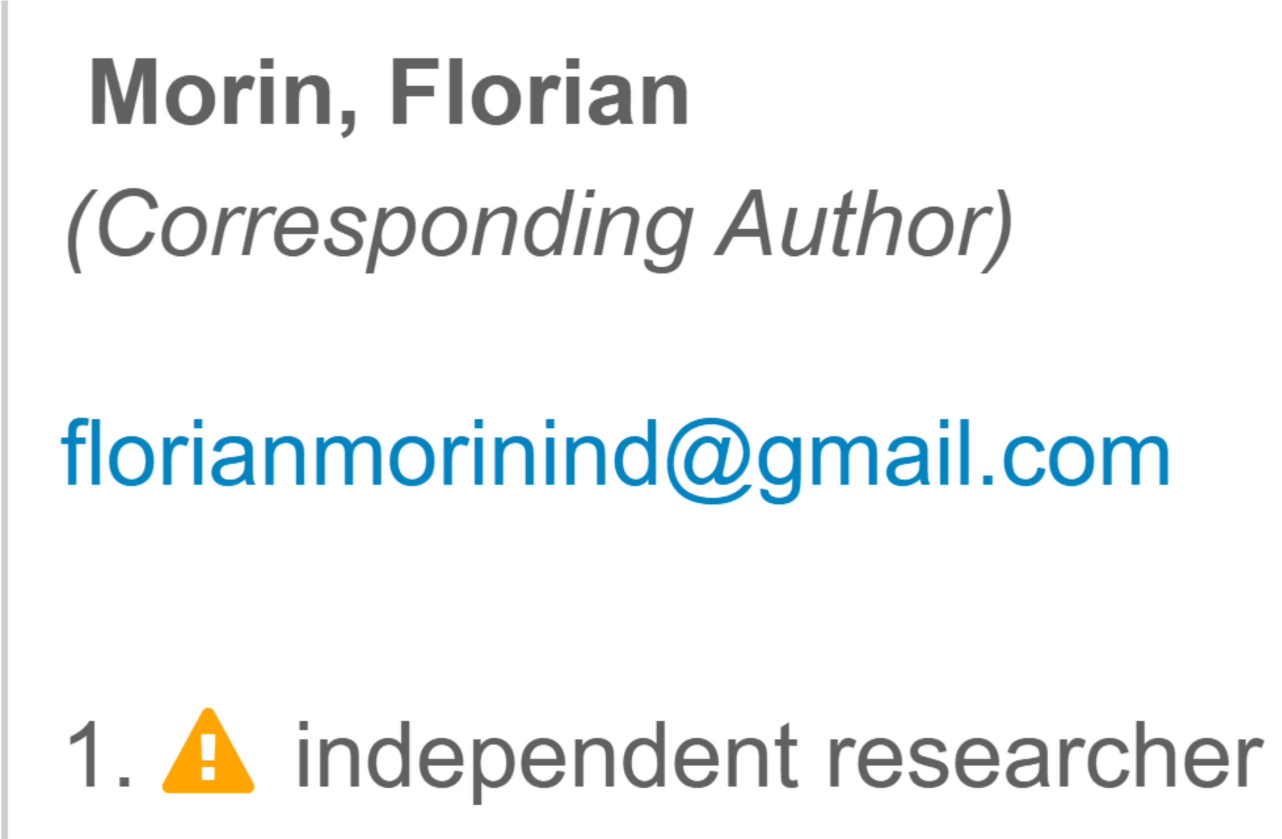


Figure 4. Affiliation field displaying “independent researcher” marked with a warning icon in the submission interface, indicating a potential mismatch between declared status and validation requirements.

Process Mapping (Entry → Progression → Completion → Persistence)

Entry

Validated. The manuscript passes initial screening and receives a specific, actionable editorial request (APA formatting)

Progression

Blocked. Following resubmission, the system maintains interaction but returns to the same request state without advancing toward peer review

Completion

Not reached. No editorial decision (acceptance or rejection) is issued

Persistence

Maintained. The submission remains visible in the system without status resolution

Context

An independent researcher submitted a manuscript to Human Factors. Following initial submission, the journal returned it with a specific and actionable request to reformat the references according to APA guidelines (including alphabetical order and hanging indentation). This indicates that the submission passed an initial screening stage and was eligible for further processing, conditional on minor formatting corrections.

Sequence of Events

Initial submission
Entry is accepted into the system
Editorial request
A precise and actionable correction is issued, indicating eligibility for progression
Resubmission
The requested changes are implemented
Post-correction phase
The system reissues the same request without advancing state. Progression does not occur

Observed Mechanism

The interaction forms a non-transition loop at the progression stage. Each response satisfies the stated requirements, yet the system returns to the same state. Responses occur at regular intervals (~8 hours), creating the appearance of activity while preventing state transition. Interaction is preserved, but progression is functionally inactive.

Observed Outcome

No progression to peer review
No acceptance
No rejection
No status resolution

Interpretation

This case shows a breakdown of progression after successful entry. The initial editorial request confirms that the manuscript entered a valid processing pathway. However, after compliance, no transition occurs toward evaluation. The process remains active in form, but inactive in function. This corresponds to a progression failure: compliance does not produce advancement, and the system fails to transition between states. The system remains in a persistent intermediate state.

Relation to Quiet Exclusion

This configuration represents quiet exclusion at the progression stage. Exclusion emerges not through rejection, but through the absence of state transition. The system remains formally open while functionally preventing progression.

Key insight

Exclusion can occur after successful entry through failure of progression. A system does not need to reject a submission to exclude it. It only needs to prevent transition between states.

Mail support. Editorial response discontinuity

Following an initial inquiry regarding submission eligibility for independent researchers, the editorial office responded within minutes with a generic reference to submission guidelines. A follow-up message explicitly requested confirmation on whether independent researchers are considered for review, and whether institutional affiliation is required. No response was received after this clarification.

This pattern indicates a shift from immediate responsiveness to non-response when the question targets explicit access conditions, suggesting that engagement is maintained at a general level but not at the point where eligibility criteria are made explicit.

Case Study 2. ResearchGate Registration

This case illustrates a failure at the entry stage of the access process. Entry appears available at the interface level but cannot be completed due to downstream verification constraints.

Process Mapping (Entry → Progression → Completion → Persistence)

Entry

Blocked. Initial registration steps are accessible, but identity verification prevents

Progression

Not reached. The user cannot enter the system as a validated participant

Completion

Not applicable

Persistence

Not applicable. Access is never established

Empirical Indicators

The platform presents multiple registration categories at the same level, including “Academic or Student” and “Independent Researcher,” suggesting equivalent entry pathways. During registration, the system allows the user to skip institutional affiliation, implying that it is optional. However, a verification message appears: “You haven't provided your institutional email. Signing up with a personal email requires extra steps for us to verify that you're a researcher - your institutional email gives you instant access.” The platform then requires authorship confirmation through pre-indexed publications. If no matching publications are found, the system returns: “Sorry, we couldn't verify that you are a researcher from the information you provided. We therefore require you to enter your institutional email address…”

Sequence of Events

Initial registration

Entry pathway appears open, including an “Independent Researcher” option

Institutional information request

Institutional affiliation is requested but can be skipped

Email verification step

Non-institutional email triggers additional verification requirements

Authorship verification

The system attempts to match the user with indexed publications

Verification failure

Entry is denied unless institutional credentials are provided

Observed Mechanism

This case reveals a conditional entry barrier. Entry is not directly denied. Instead, the system allows partial progression through registration steps while deferring validation requirements. The “skip” option functions as a nominal pathway that does not lead to successful entry. Verification constraints are reintroduced at a later stage, creating a delayed entry failure.

Observed Outcome

No successful account creation
No validated researcher status
No alternative verification pathway
Entry remains incomplete

Interpretation

This case shows a misalignment between interface-level access and process-level access. The presence of an “Independent Researcher” category suggests open entry. However, downstream verification mechanisms depend on institutional affiliation or pre-indexed publications. Entry is therefore not blocked at the initial step, but at the point of validation.

Relation to Quiet Exclusion

This configuration represents quiet exclusion at the entry stage. The system permits initial interaction, signals optional requirements, and reintroduces constraints through verification. Exclusion is not expressed as rejection, but as an inability to complete entry.

Key Insight

Entry can fail through conditional verification structures. A system does not need to deny access explicitly. It can allow partial entry while ensuring that completion depends on implicit legitimacy signals.

Case Study 3. Automated Restriction and Non-Response Following Active Use on Zenodo

The system removes the record and blocks the account without prior warning, see Figure 5.

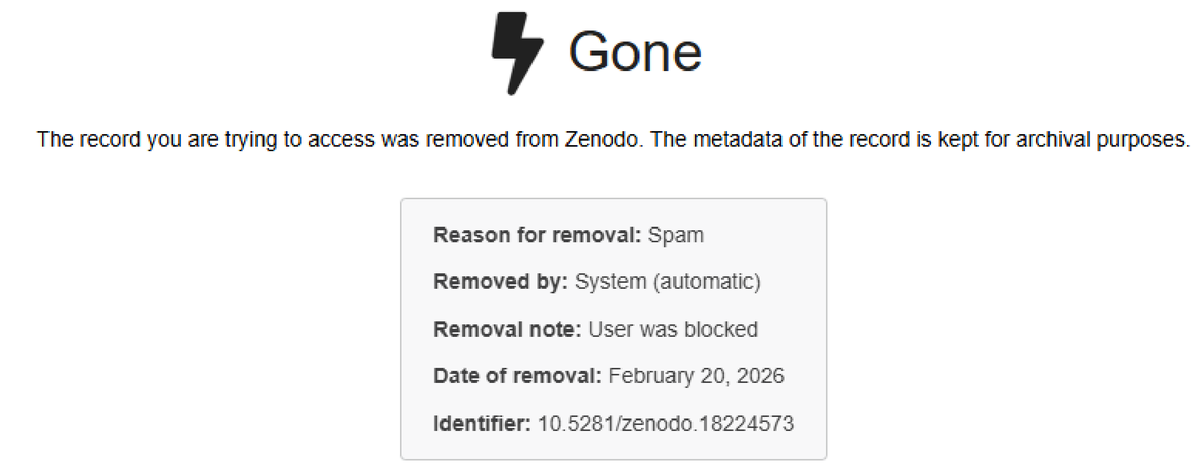


Figure 5. Record labeled as “spam” and removed, accompanied by account blocking. No detailed justification or recovery pathway is provided, and the record becomes inaccessible.

This is not a moderated decision with explanation. It is an immediate classification without a recovery pathway. The platform presents itself as safe, open, and immediately accessible, see Figure 6.

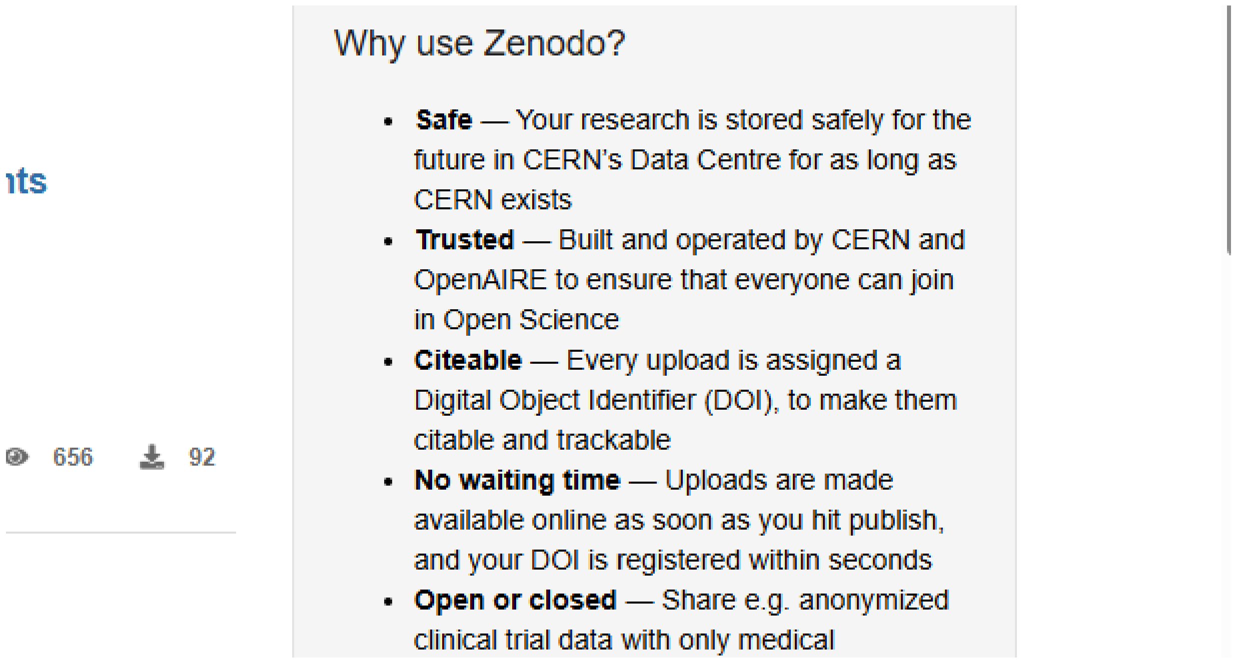


Figure 6. Zenodo homepage highlighting safety, trust, openness, and immediate availability.

These claims contrast with the observed restriction and lack of response. Access is presented as immediate, but does not materialize in practice.

The platform explicitly acknowledges that moderation processes may produce misclassifications, as shown in Figure 7.

Zenodo FAQ › Content › What can I do to avoid spam detection?

What can I do to avoid spam detection?

Everything you post or submit on Zenodo is subject to automated and/or manual review by our automated spam classification system. The system is dealing with large volumes of submissions on a daily basis, and while we strive to make it as accurate as possible, the system may occasionally make mistakes. The following is some of the actions you can take to ensure the spam classification system has enough information to determine your upload is ham.

1. Register with an institutional email address (avoid generic mail providers)

We encourage you to register with an institutional email address (e.g. provided by a university). If you already registered with another email address you can change your email address. We have very little spam from users having an institutional email address, and thus an institutional email address is a strong indicator that a submission is not spam. On the other hand, we have significant amount of spam coming from users using generic mail providers like gmail, outlook, yahoo and others. For help on how to create an account or change email address see:

- https://help.zenodo.org/docs/get-started/create-an-account/
- https://help.zenodo.org/docs/profile/editing-your-profile/#edit

Figure 7. Platform statement acknowledging that both automated and manual moderation processes may produce misclassifications. By presenting institutional email addresses as reducing spam risk, the platform normalizes a status-filtering mechanism while framing it as a neutral security measure.

Strict moderation policies are understandable. However, when error correction depends on non-responsive channels, false positives may become **stable exclusion states.** This leads to the outcome illustrated in Figure 8.

This configuration illustrates how exclusion can occur in practice: in the absence of any communicated decision, access is effectively terminated.

Ummm this is old news. I released an entire body of work that is closed testable and falsifiable that bypasses academic silos and gave it away cc0 so zenodo deleted my account behind my back. When I queried them they blocked my browser from even accessing the home page.

8:13 AM · Mar 19, 2026 · **51** Views · Twitter for Android

Figure 8. No rejection. No decision. The outcome is removal, silence, and loss of access.

Case Study 3. Zenodo Platform Restriction

(Progression Disruption and Persistence Failure After Entry)

This case illustrates exclusion occurring after successful entry and sustained progression. Access is initially granted and used, but later disrupted and not restored.

Process Mapping (Entry → Progression → Completion → Persistence)

Entry

Validated. The researcher successfully creates an account and uploads multiple

Progression

Achieved, then disrupted. The platform supports sustained activity, including

Completion

Interrupted. Ongoing research activity cannot continue due to account restriction

Persistence

Failed. Access is not restored following restriction due to prolonged non-response from support

Empirical Indicators

The researcher actively used Zenodo over a period of approximately six weeks, uploading and updating multiple documents using standard platform features (Appendix 2). Following this period, the account was automatically flagged or restricted for spam-related reasons, without prior warning or explanation (Figure 5). After contacting support, the system indicated that a confirmation message would be sent. No confirmation was received. No response was obtained over a period exceeding four weeks, leaving the account in a restricted state. Platform communication continues to emphasize openness and accessibility (Figure 6), while filtering mechanisms rely on implicit legitimacy signals such as institutional affiliation (Figure 7).

Sequence of Events

Initial uploads

Entry is successful, and documents are uploaded

Sustained activity phase

The researcher engages in normal platform use, including versioning and updates

Automated restriction

The account is flagged or restricted without explicit justification

Post-restriction phase

A support request is submitted. A confirmation is expected but not received

Non-response period

No response is provided over several weeks. Access remains restricted

Observed Mechanism

This case reveals a post-entry progression disruption combined with persistence failure. The system allows entry and sustained use, then introduces an automated restriction without transparent criteria. Following restriction, the absence of support response prevents clarification or recovery. The process remains formally open, but no mechanism enables state restoration.

Observed Outcome

Access revoked after sustained use
No explanation of triggering condition
No restoration of account
No response from support
The system stabilizes in a restricted state

Interpretation

This case shows a breakdown occurring after both entry and progression have been achieved. The researcher successfully integrates into the platform and engages in standard activity. However, access is later revoked through automated classification. The absence of response prevents transition toward resolution. This corresponds to a combined progression and persistence failure: activity is interrupted, and recovery is not possible.

Relation to Quiet Exclusion

This configuration represents quiet exclusion in a post-access context. The system: allows entry, supports progression, introduces restriction, fails to restore access.

Exclusion emerges not through denial of entry, but through disruption and non-recovery. The process remains visible, but functionally inactive.

Key Insight

Exclusion can occur after successful participation through the combination of automated restriction and absence of recovery pathways. A system does not need to block entry to exclude. It can allow access, interrupt it, and prevent restoration. See Figure 9 for an illustration of classification ambiguity arising from overlap between automated filtering heuristics and legitimate research workflows. This suggests that classification operates in a regime of overlap rather than separation.

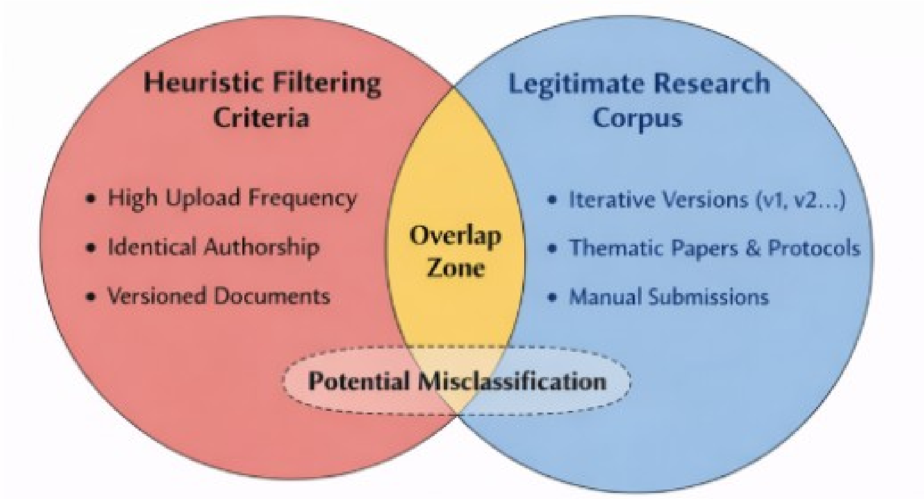


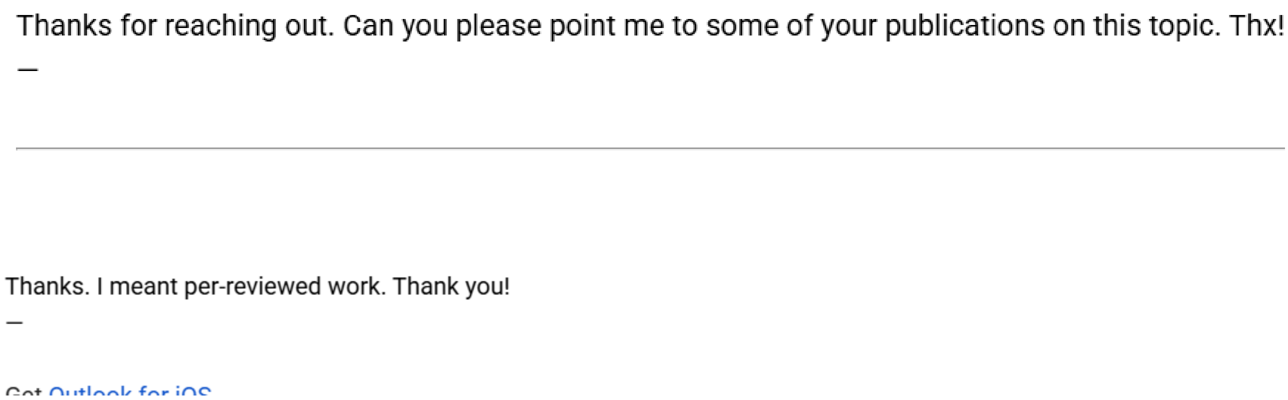
Figure 9. Overlap between automated filtering heuristics and legitimate research workflows, creating ambiguity in classification. Within this region, automated systems may produce false positives without clear justification. Legitimate research practices become indistinguishable from filtered behaviors, enabling exclusion without explicit decision.

Asymmetric Moderation and Conditional Restoration

The platform explicitly states that access and content will be restored in cases of erroneous spam classification. However, this guarantee operates within a structurally asymmetric system. Moderation actions are immediate, automated, and potentially account-wide, while correction depends on user-initiated contact and subsequent manual review. In practice, this creates a sequence in which removal precedes verification. Content and access may be fully withdrawn before any assessment of error is completed, generating an intermediate state of uncertainty. During this period, the affected user must rely on the visibility, responsiveness, and effectiveness of support channels to recover access. Although the system formally acknowledges the possibility of error and provides a restoration pathway, this pathway is conditional rather than intrinsic. The burden of resolution is transferred to the user, and successful recovery is not guaranteed within a defined timeframe. As a result, the system combines three properties: strict enforcement, explicit acknowledgment of fallibility, and delayed, contingent correction. This configuration allows for high-impact exclusion without explicit rejection, particularly in cases where support interaction fails to produce timely resolution.

Case Study 4. Pre-Review Filtering in Informal Scientific Exchange

This case illustrates a failure at the entry stage of the access process. Entry appears available at the interaction level but cannot be completed due to legitimacy preconditions, see Figure 10.


Thanks for reaching out. Can you please point me to some of your publications on this topic. Thx!
—

Thanks. I meant per-reviewed work. Thank you!
—

Get Outlook for iOS

Figure 10. Editorial response limiting consideration to peer-reviewed work

Process Mapping (Entry → Progression → Completion → Persistence)

Entry
Blocked. Initial contact is established, but access to evaluation is conditioned on prior peer-reviewed publications

Progression
Not reached. The content is not engaged with or evaluated

Completion
Not applicable

Persistence
Not applicable. Evaluation is never initiated

Empirical Indicators

The interaction begins with an apparently open request: the academic asks for "publications on this topic," suggesting willingness to engage. The researcher provides multiple materials, including a structured framework (PDF) and additional documents available online.

A clarification is then introduced: "I meant peer-reviewed work."

This establishes a restriction on what counts as valid input for evaluation. Materials that do not meet this criterion are not considered.

Sequence of Events

Initial contact
A theoretical framework is presented, with a request for feedback

Request for publications
The academic asks for prior publications, implying conditional openness

Submission of materials
The researcher provides non-peer-reviewed documents and a corpus page

Clarification of requirement
The academic specifies that only peer-reviewed work is acceptable

Termination of interaction
No further evaluation or engagement occurs

Observed Mechanism

This case reveals a pre-review filtering mechanism. Access to evaluation is not denied directly. Instead, it is conditioned on prior validation within the same system.

The requirement for peer-reviewed work functions as a gatekeeping condition that precedes any assessment of the submitted content. Evaluation is deferred indefinitely unless this condition is satisfied.

Observed Outcome

No evaluation of the submitted work.
No feedback on the framework.
No alternative pathway for consideration.
Interaction ends without explicit rejection.

Interpretation

This case shows a recursive validation structure. Evaluation requires prior evaluation. Legitimacy functions both as the condition and the outcome of access.

Unlike interface-level systems, where constraints are embedded in procedures, this mechanism operates through internalized norms. The requirement is not enforced by a platform, but by expectations regarding acceptable forms of scientific output.

Relation to Quiet Exclusion

This configuration represents quiet exclusion at the entry stage. The interaction remains formally open and cooperative, but access to evaluation is never granted.

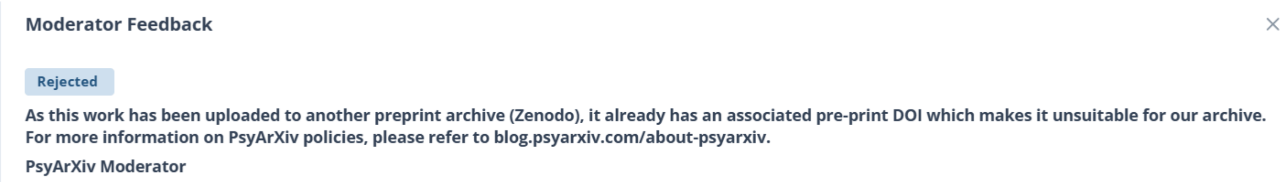
Exclusion does not take the form of rejection, delay, or procedural loop. It occurs through theintroduction of a precondition that cannot be satisfied at the point of entry.

Key Insight

Evaluation can be prevented by upstream legitimacy requirements. A system does not need to reject a contribution explicitly. It can require prior validation as a condition for engagement, resulting in the non-initiation of evaluation.

Variants of Access Filtering in Other Preprint Platforms

Preprint platforms are often described as open infrastructures enabling rapid and broad dissemination of scientific work. However, access conditions vary across platforms and reveal distinct forms of entry regulation that can differentially affect independent researchers. On arXiv, access to submission is mediated through an endorsement system in certain subject areas. New authors must be endorsed by an established contributor before they are allowed to submit. This mechanism is explicit and formally documented, making the entry barrier visible. However, it introduces a dependency on existing network connections, which may disadvantage researchers without prior integration into academic networks. Platforms such as PsyArXiv and other Open Science Framework-based repositories operate under a more permissive model, allowing submissions without formal endorsement requirements. While PsyArXiv and OSF may introduce less visible forms of regulation during or after submission, Figure 11 illustrates a contrasting form of exclusion, where access is explicitly denied through predefined content criteria rather than emerging from procedural opacity. bioRxiv represents an intermediate configuration. While institutional affiliation is not strictly required, submissions are subject to editorial screening and identity verification. As illustrated in Appendix 3, access barriers across scientific platforms form a continuum, ranging from explicit requirements (e.g., endorsement or credential checks) to increasingly implicit and opaque forms of selection, culminating in editorial discretion. The following example documents a case of explicit access restriction based on platform policy enforcement.



Moderator Feedback

Rejected

As this work has been uploaded to another preprint archive (Zenodo), it already has an associated pre-print DOI which makes it unsuitable for our archive. For more information on PsyArXiv policies, please refer to blog.psyarxiv.com/about-psyarxiv.

PsyArXiv Moderator

Figure 11. Moderator feedback indicating rejection based on AI-generated content. A secondary justification refers to a preprint hosted on another platform, but the link was not accessible at the time, introducing a non-verifiable condition.

This work, currently under review, was submitted to PsyArXiv (earlier version, v1), and thefollowing response was received, see Figure 12.

Moderator Feedback

Rejected

For submissions in this format (case studies/opinion pieces), we need to look at the author's expertise via past publications. This policy ensures that submissions are grounded in appropriate expertise to support productive scientific discourse in psychology. As we found no record of previous relevant peer-reviewed publications by the author(s) in a brief search, we cannot accept the work into the repository. We acknowledge the irony of this given the topic of the opinion piece/case study and we recently updated our moderation policy to be more transparent. PsyArXiv does accept postprints, so we would welcome you reaching out to us again in the case where the work is accepted in a publication with editorial oversight that publishes articles about psychology, even if it is not peer reviewed (Medium, WONKHE, and the Conversation are examples familiar to us). This moderation decision is final. Please do not resubmit. If you think your submission was incorrectly rejected, see https://blog.psyarxiv.com/about-psyarxiv#appeals for information on how to appeal this decision.

PsyArXiv Moderator

Figure 12. Expertise is treated as a credential, not as something demonstrable within the work : It's not rejecting ideas, it's filtering who gets evaluated.

Across these platforms, multiple mechanisms are used to regulate access: explicit social validation through endorsement systems, editorial and identity-based screening, automated or semi-automated filtering processes, and variations in moderation and support responsiveness. Despite these differences, a common pattern emerges. Access is not uniformly open but conditioned by forms of validation that often depend on prior integration into the scientific system. As a result, independent researchers may face higher uncertainty, additional verification requirements, or prolonged non-response compared to institutionally affiliated users. In some cases, submissions may also be deprioritized or rejected based on perceived authorship concerns related to large language models. This introduces a distinct form of attribution-based exclusion, where decisions are influenced by assumptions about how the work was produced rather than by its content or procedural status. This mode differs from process-based exclusion. While process-based exclusion operates through disruption of entry, progression, or completion, attribution-based exclusion operates at the level of perceived legitimacy of authorship, independently of the procedural flow. A distinct form of access limitation arises from predefined participation conditions, as illustrated in Figure 13.

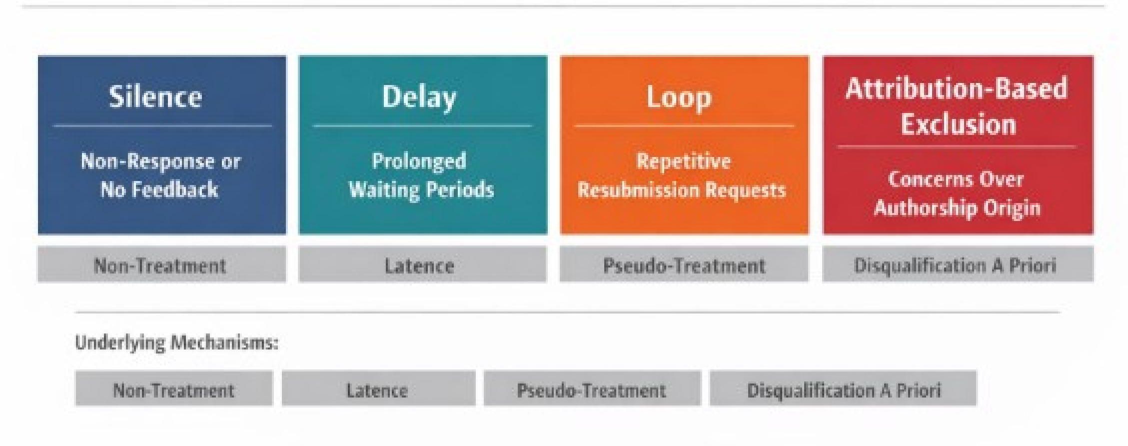


Figure 13. Typology of quiet exclusion mechanisms in scientific systems. Silence, delay, loop, and attribution-based exclusion define distinct process-level barriers. Together, these mechanisms constrain participation without explicit rejection while preventing resolution.

These mechanisms differ in form but share a common property: participation is initiated, but does not reach completion.

+ Eligibility-based exclusion (pre-entry constraint, Figure 14)

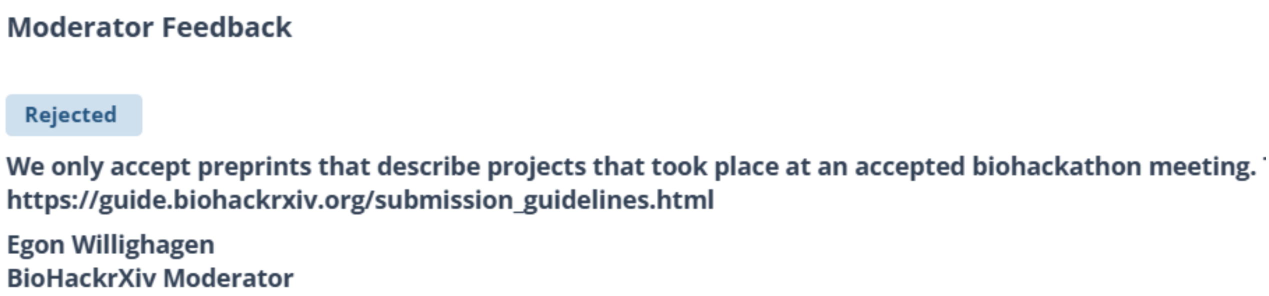


Figure 14. Access restricted to submissions meeting predefined participation conditions, independent of content evaluation, illustrating a policy-based form of exclusion.

BOX 1 Internalized Exclusion and Self-Disqualification

In addition to observable barriers, asymmetries in research environments give rise to internalized mechanisms that shape participation. Institutional settings distribute evaluative functions across a range of actors and processes, from supervision to peer review, and provide access to resources that facilitate interpretation and adjustment. This distribution reduces the extent to which individuals must independently resolve uncertainty, as evaluative load is partially absorbed by the surrounding infrastructure.

In contrast, independent researchers often operate in isolation, without access to iterative feedback, institutional validation signals, or collaborative calibration. As a result, evaluative processes become internalized and continuous. Quiet exclusion amplifies this condition by withholding explicit decisions and providing only ambiguous or delayed feedback. In the absence of clear external judgment, independent researchers are driven to interpret non-response, stalled processes, or procedural friction as indicators of their own illegitimacy.

Under these conditions, ordinary imperfections may acquire disproportionate interpretive weight. Minor deviations from expected norms can be perceived as critical failures, particularly in the absence of explicit feedback. This produces an asymmetry in which perceived errors exceed their actual causal impact on outcomes. Where institutional contexts diffuse evaluation across multiple actors, independent researchers are more likely to internalize it, resulting in sustained self-monitoring under conditions of uncertainty and weak structure.

This internalization contributes to the stability of quiet exclusion mechanisms. Because exclusion is interpreted as self-disqualification rather than system-level failure, it generates limited contestation and low external visibility. The absence of explicit rejection not only prevents appeal but also shifts explanatory responsibility toward the individual, reinforcing the persistence of the system without requiring active enforcement. People can tolerate rejection more easily than indefinite procedural silence. At least rejection admits that a gate exists.

Informal Norms and Social Signaling

Social signaling mechanisms may also produce a form of anticipatory exclusion, as shown in Figure 15. Individuals navigating scientific spaces often internalize expected audience reactions, adjusting their behavior accordingly. When independence is associated with low status or fringe positioning, contributors may preemptively withdraw, delay submission, or modify how their work is presented. This anticipatory adaptation does not require direct rejection to be effective. Instead, it operates through expectation, reducing participation before formal evaluation is even initiated.

Figure 15. Example of status-based disqualification in a public discussion, where independent researcher identity functions as a legitimacy filter independent of content (source: Reddit, r/neuro).

From Isolated Events to Systemic Pattern

Although each instance may appear explainable in isolation, their repetition across distinct platforms indicates convergence toward a common process. The persistence of similar access limitations, regardless of institutional context, implies that these outcomes arise from shared structural conditions rather than platform-specific anomalies. Quiet exclusion thus emerges as a cross-system phenomenon, shaped by recurring configurations of validation, response dynamics, and decision-making under uncertainty.

Box 2. Informal Adaptation and System Circumvention

In response to access barriers encountered on scientific platforms, independent researchers may develop informal adaptation strategies aimed at bypassing validation constraints. These practices typically emerge as reactive adjustments to opaque or unresponsive access mechanisms rather than as primary intentions.

Reports from online discussions suggest that some users attempt to circumvent institutional requirements by providing incomplete, approximate, or unverifiable affiliations. In such cases, affiliation fields may be filled strategically to satisfy platform expectations rather than to accurately reflect institutional belonging. This indicates that validation systems may operate less as measures of research quality and more as proxies for institutional conformity.

These adaptations reveal a structural tension within ostensibly open platforms. While access is formally available, effective entry conditions incentivize alignment with institutional signals, including artificially constructed ones. As a result, systems may favor those able to reproduce expected markers of legitimacy over those who cannot, independently of the intrinsic value of their work.

Importantly, circumvention does not eliminate exclusion but redistributes it. Individuals unwilling or unable to engage in such strategies remain blocked, while others gain access through partial compliance. This produces an uneven participation landscape in which access depends not only on formal criteria but also on the ability to interpret and navigate implicit system expectations.

From a systemic perspective, the emergence of informal adaptation strategies indicates that barriers are both active and perceived as negotiable. This negotiability does not imply openness; rather, it reflects a misalignment between declared accessibility and operational constraints. The need for circumvention can therefore be interpreted as indirect evidence of structural exclusion. When access requires circumvention, openness is conditional rather than actual, see Figure 16.

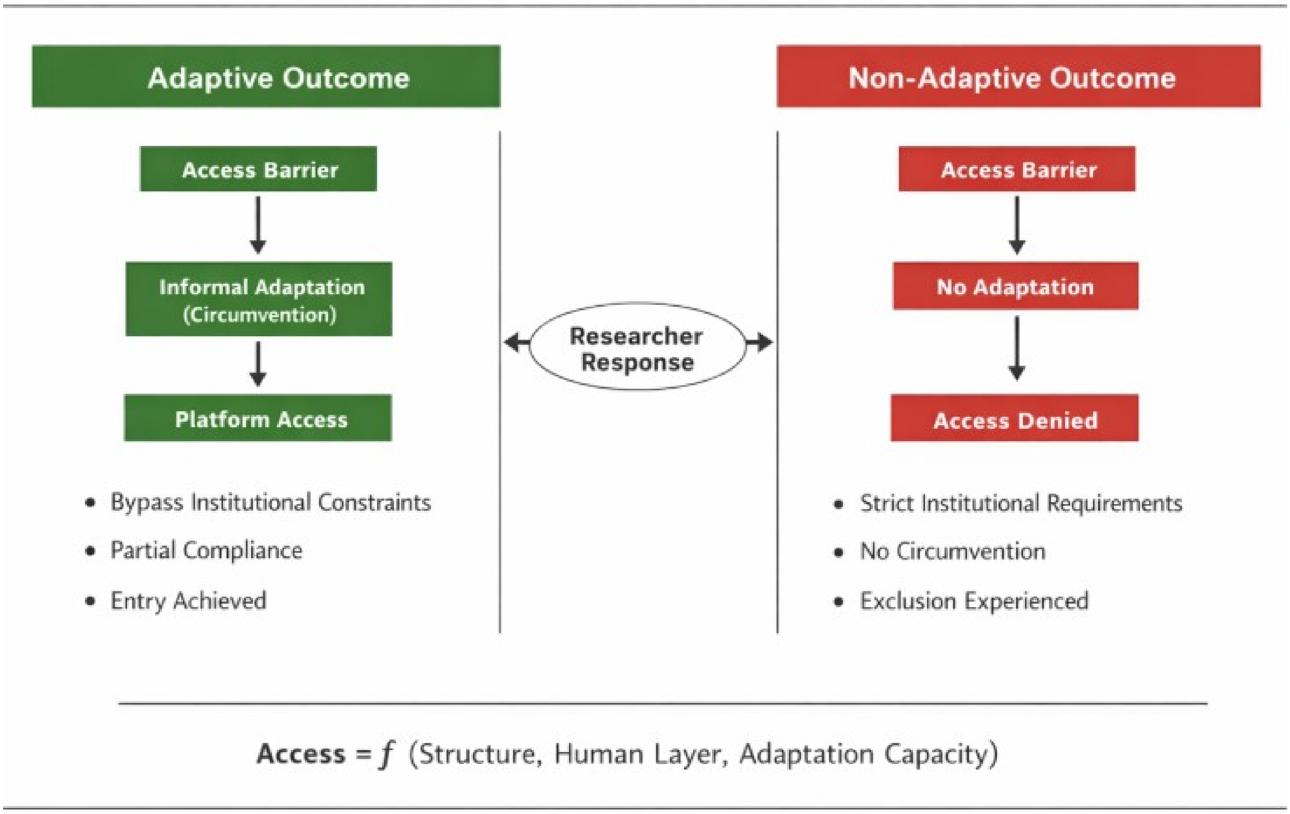


Figure 16. Adaptation enables entry, while non-adaptation leads to exclusion at the entry stage.

Human-Mediated Exclusion in Journal Submission Processes

The dynamics observed in platform access are not limited to account creation or automated validation systems. Comparable patterns emerge within journal submission processes, where human decision-making plays a central role. Beyond formal criteria such as editorial scope or formatting requirements, independent researchers may encounter exclusion mediated by human factors, including desk rejection, non-response, or implicit credibility filtering. As with platform-based mechanisms, these outcomes are not always accompanied by explicit justification.

In some cases, submissions are neither formally reviewed nor clearly rejected, but receive minimal engagement or standardized responses that do not provide actionable feedback. This produces an indeterminate status, in which the author cannot distinguish between content-based rejection and exclusion linked to perceived legitimacy. Editorial evaluation often relies on heuristics such as institutional affiliation, prior publication history, or recognizable academic signals. While these heuristics support efficiency, they can also function as implicit filters, particularly at early stages of review, disadvantageous to researchers who lack these markers.
This suggests that quiet exclusion is not confined to automated systems but extends into human-mediated evaluation environments. Structural criteria and informal legitimacy assessments combine to form a layered filtering process, where access may be constrained without explicit policy-level exclusion. As a result, independent researchers may face cumulative barriers across both platforms and journals, with each stage introducing uncertainty, opacity, and a reduced likelihood of integration into formal scientific communication channels. Human and automated systems differ in form, but converge in producing exclusion through low-visibility filtering mechanisms.

BOX 3: Ordinary Participation, Invisible Exclusion

What makes quiet exclusion particularly difficult to perceive is that it often become visible only through ordinary human situations. The issue is not limited to ambitious cases or to individuals at the margins of institutional science. It can affect people who appear entirely unremarkable, individuals quietly working alone, with modest aims, limited visibility, and no claim to exceptional status. Precisely this ordinariness makes the phenomenon more striking. A person may produce a small number of documents, openly acknowledge the limits of their work, and seek only to share it through standard scientific channels. Yet even this minimal form of participation can be interrupted by silent bans, non-response, or filtering rules tied to institutional markers such as email domain. In such cases, exclusion does not appear as a dramatic rejection, but as something quieter and, for that reason, more brutal: an ordinary person engaged in ordinary scientific work is rendered invisible without ever being clearly addressed as such.

Core Theory: Access as a Process of State Transitions

Scientific participation is typically described in terms of discrete outcomes, most notably acceptance or rejection. However, access to scientific communication is more accurately understood as a process unfolding across multiple stages. Participation may be constrained before any final decision is reached. We define access as a process composed of three necessary components:

Access = Entry × Progression × Completion

Entry refers to the ability to access a platform or initiate participation.
Progression refers to movement through validation or evaluation stages.
Completion refers to the ability to reach a final decision, whether acceptance or rejection.
Because these components are multiplicative, failure at any stage reduces access to zero. As a result, exclusion does not require explicit rejection. It can arise from blocked entry, stalled progression, or absence of completion. This process can be represented as a sequence of state transitions from entry to completion, see Figure 17. Each component corresponds to a transition within the system. Access requires the successful completion of this sequence.

Quiet exclusion occurs when at least one transition does not occur. The process may be initiated, and interaction may be maintained, yet progression fails or completion is never reached. In such cases, participation does not occur despite the absence of rejection. The defining feature of quiet exclusion is not the absence of interaction, but the absence of state transition. Systems may appear open at the interface level while failing to sustain progression at the process level.

Access requires successful transition from entry to completion. Quiet exclusion occurs when this transition sequence fails. Interaction may be maintained, but the process does not reach completion.

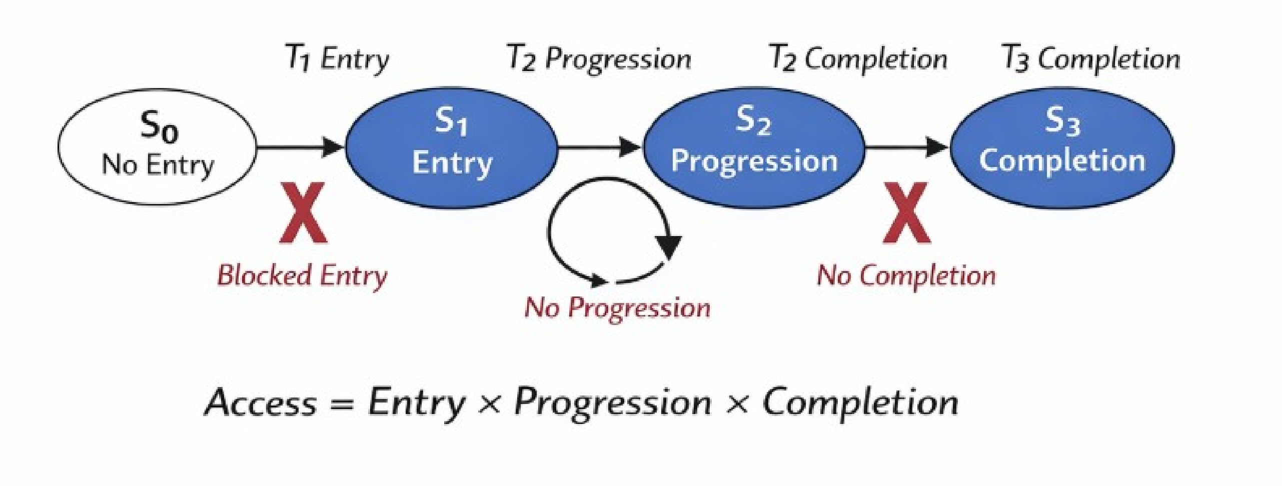


Figure 17. This framework provides a unified interpretation of the observed cases, in which different mechanisms converge toward a common outcome: interaction without completion.

Access requires successful transition from entry to completion.

Access = Entry × Progression × Completion

Quiet exclusion occurs when at least one transition fails. Interaction may be maintained, but the process does not reach completion.

Core Theory v2: Access as a Process of State Transitions

Scientific participation is typically described in terms of discrete outcomes, most notably acceptance or rejection. However, access to scientific communication is more accurately understood as a process unfolding across multiple stages. Participation may be constrained before any final decision is reached, or disrupted after initial dissemination.

We define access as a process composed of four necessary components:

Access = Entry × Progression × Completion × Persistence

Entry refers to the ability to access a platform or initiate participation.
Progression refers to movement through validation or evaluation stages.
Completion refers to the ability to reach a final decision, whether acceptance or rejection.
Persistence refers to the continued availability and stability of a contribution within the scientific record over time.

Because these components are multiplicative, failure at any stage reduces access to zero. Exclusion does not require explicit rejection. It can arise from blocked entry, stalled progression, absence of completion, or loss of persistence after dissemination.

This process can be represented as a sequence of state transitions from entry to completion, extended by a persistence phase, as illustrated in Figure 18. Access requires the successful completion of this sequence and the continued stability of its outcome.

Quiet exclusion occurs when at least one transition does not occur or when persistence fails after initial completion. The process may be initiated, interaction may be maintained, and even completion may be reached, yet access can still collapse if the contribution does not remain available.

The defining feature of quiet exclusion is not the absence of interaction, but the failure of the process to sustain state transitions through to persistence. Systems may appear open and functional at the interface level while failing to maintain access at the level of process or record stability.

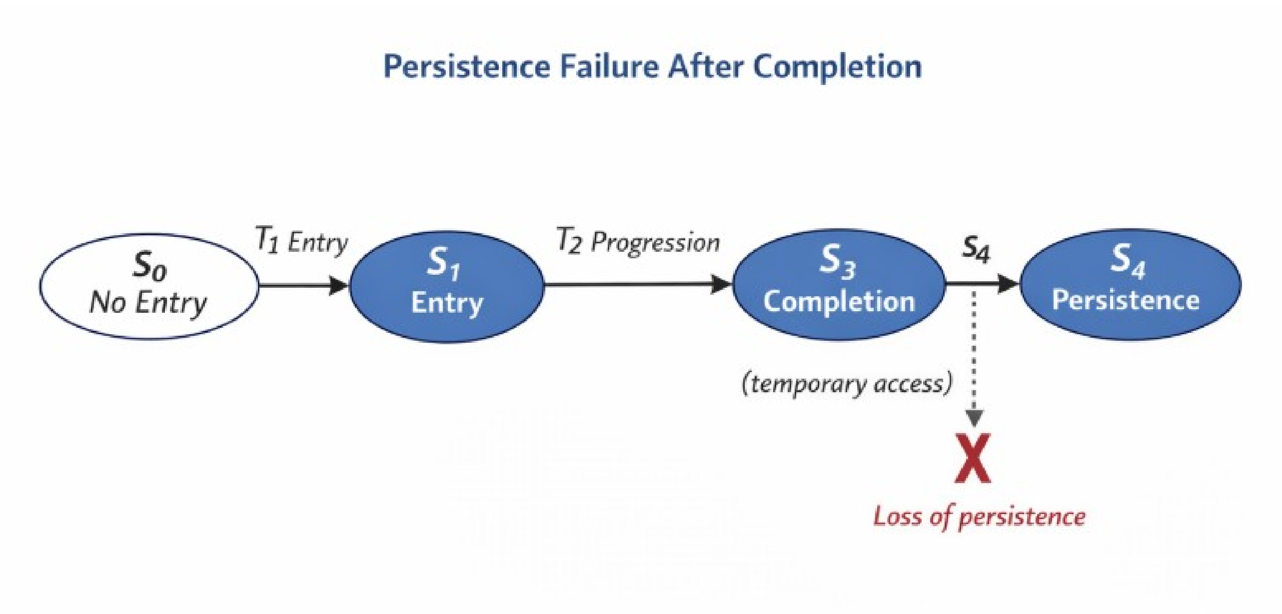
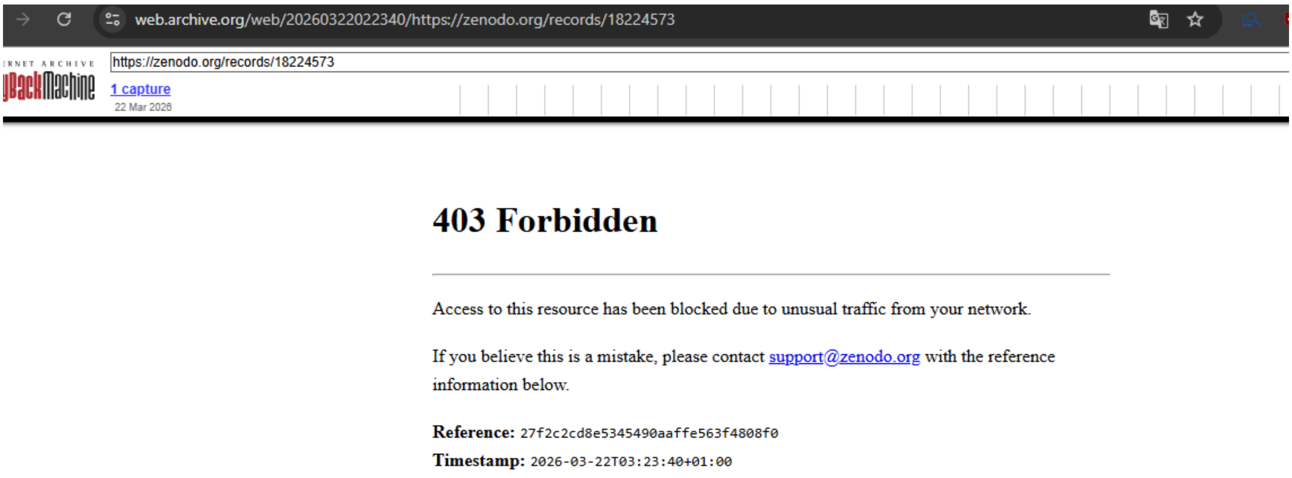


Figure 18. Persistence failure after completion. A process may reach completion while access remains unstable over time.

A critical feature of persistence failures is that they affect materials that have already entered the scientific record. Content may receive initial views or downloads, yet subsequently disappear, interrupting an ongoing process of dissemination. Previously accessible contributions become non-retrievable after partial integration into the attention space of the community.

Citability discontinuity refers to a condition in which a scientific contribution transitions from accessible and potentially citable to effectively non-retrievable, despite prior evidence of access, visibility, or engagement.

This creates a discontinuity in citability: a contribution transitions from accessible to effectively non-existent, despite evidence of prior engagement. This dynamic extends beyond direct user access and becomes visible in interactions with archival systems, see Figure 19.



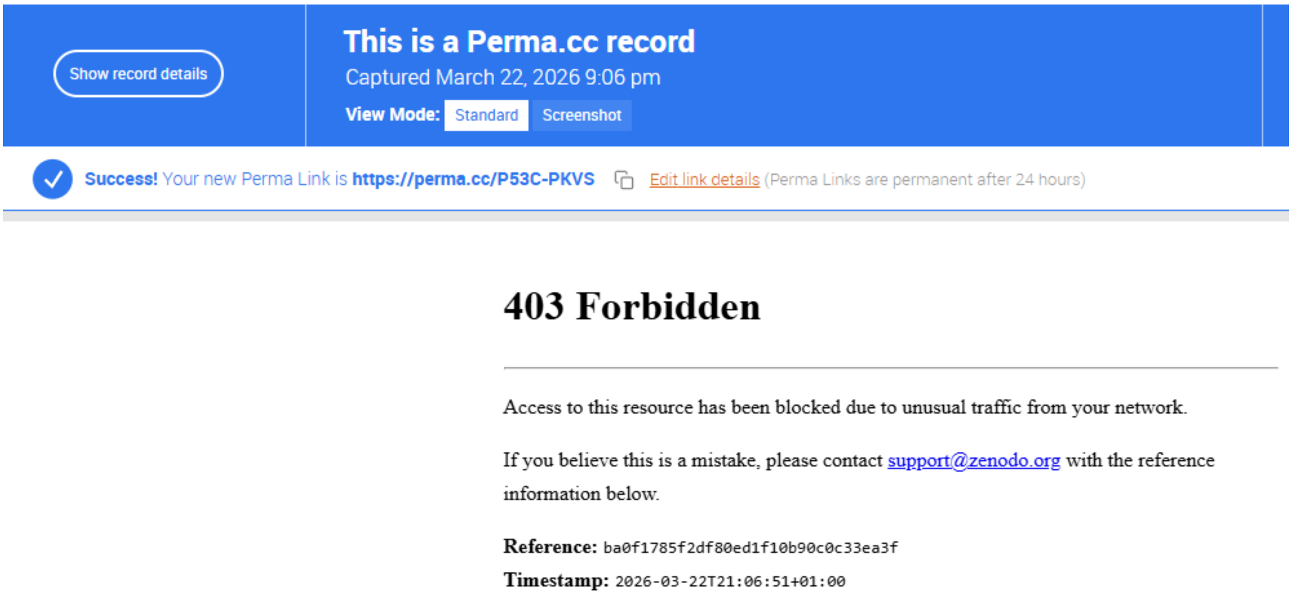


Figure 19. Example of archival-level access restriction. Content remains accessible to individual users but is blocked from automated or proxy-based archiving systems, preventing reliable capture and preservation.

Citability discontinuity: A contribution is accessible, then becomes non-retrievable despite prior visibility or engagement.

While quiet exclusion prevents participation without rejection, citability discontinuity affects contributions after dissemination by interrupting their persistence in the scientific record. Both mechanisms operate without explicit decision and without clear attribution. Two distinct mechanisms of exclusion can be identified within this framework: process failure and persistence failure, as shown in Figure 20.

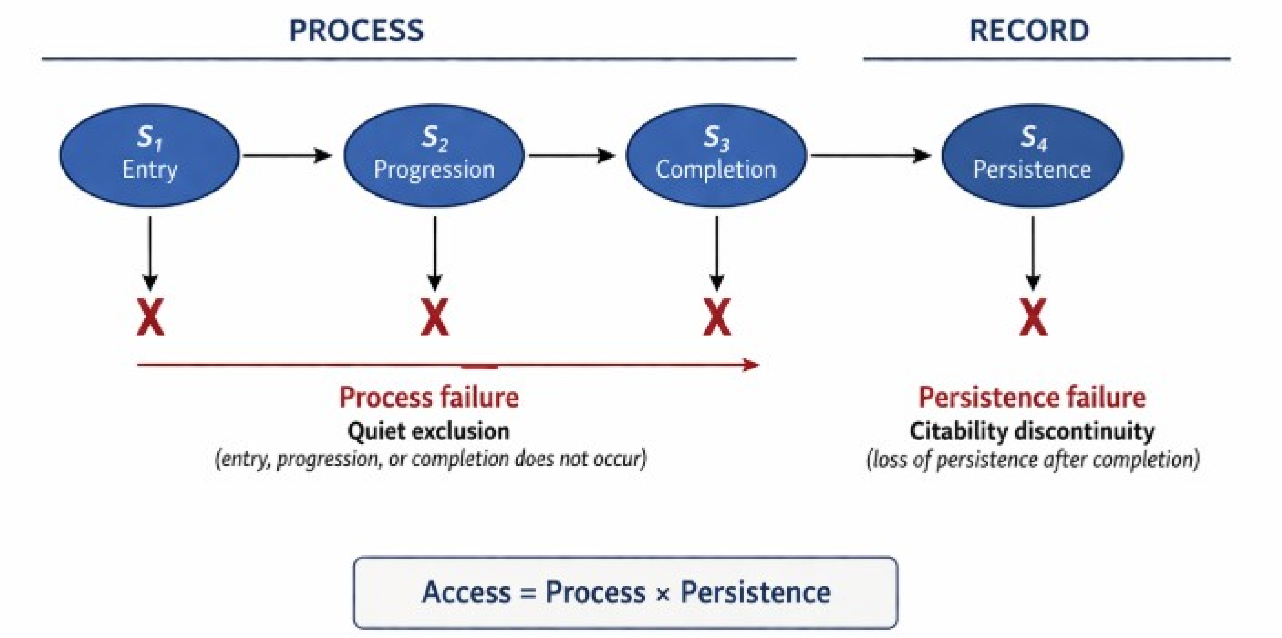


Figure 20. Process and persistence failures in scientific access. Quiet exclusion prevents participation without rejection. Citability discontinuity removes access after completion despite prior availability. Together, these mechanisms produce exclusion without decision.

Reframing Scientific Openness

This model suggests that openness cannot be evaluated solely by who is allowed to submit or by acceptance rates. Instead, openness must be assessed across the full process: the ability to enter, to progress, and to reach a decision. A system that is open at entry but fails at progression or completion remains functionally exclusionary. In this model, access is not determined by acceptance, but by the ability to complete the process. Among the identified mechanisms, delay plays a central role. By maintaining the appearance of ongoing evaluation while preventing timely completion, delay enables exclusion without conflict or visibility. It reduces the need for explicit rejection while preserving procedural legitimacy. As such, delay constitutes a structurally stable and scalable form of exclusion across both platforms and journal systems. Importantly, these mechanisms do not necessarily result from deliberate intent. They may emerge from routine system dynamics, including workload distribution, prioritization heuristics, and evolving concerns about authorship and legitimacy. However, the absence of intent does not reduce their effects. From the participant's perspective, the outcome remains consistent: limited access, prolonged uncertainty, and eventual disengagement. Recognizing these processes has direct implications for how scientific openness is evaluated. Openness cannot be inferred solely from the absence of rejection or the existence of submission pathways. It must be assessed in terms of whether participants can enter, progress, and reach completion within a reasonable timeframe. The purpose of this analysis is not to critique specific platforms, but to reveal a general process-level mechanism that remains invisible under outcome-based models. A system can be open in form and closed in outcome.

Discussion

This study examined access barriers encountered by independent researchers across scientific platforms and publication processes, with particular attention to forms of exclusion that occur without explicit rejection. The findings support the existence of a mechanism referred to as quiet exclusion, in which access is constrained through non-response, delayed processing, or implicit validation requirements rather than formal denial. Across cases, exclusion may arise at entry, during validation, or after active participation, indicating that barriers are distributed across the full lifecycle of scientific interaction.

A key implication is that exclusion in contemporary scientific systems does not rely solely on explicit gatekeeping. Instead, it emerges from the interaction between structural requirements and human-mediated processes. Institutional affiliation, email domain, and recognizable academic signals function as heuristic proxies for legitimacy, influencing whether submissions are processed, prioritized, or ignored. Access is therefore shaped not only by content or quality, but also by initial signals of conformity to institutional norms. This framework may connect to broader models in which evaluative load acts as a general constraint on system entry and engagement (Morin, 2026).

Quiet exclusion differs from traditional rejection in both form and consequence. Explicit rejection provides a defined outcome, along with feedback, justification, and potential avenues for revision or appeal. In contrast, quiet exclusion produces indeterminate states: submissions are neither accepted nor rejected, but remain suspended in prolonged uncertainty. While both mechanisms may result in access denial, they differ in visibility, traceability, and accountability. Online discussions suggest that independent researchers frequently encounter validation ambiguity, dependence on institutional email, and prolonged non-response. In response, some users report adopting informal strategies, such as declaring fictitious affiliations, indicating that access barriers are not only present but actively navigated.

The recurrence of similar patterns across platforms, preprint systems, and journal workflows suggests that this form of exclusion is not incidental. Rather, it may emerge from the structure of scientific infrastructures themselves, which rely on distributed validation, limited support capacity, and implicit norms of legitimacy. Within such systems, non-response functions as a low-cost filtering mechanism, allowing participation to be restricted without requiring explicit decisions.

The presence of informal adaptation strategies introduces an additional asymmetry. Individuals able or willing to reproduce expected signals of legitimacy may gain access, while others remain excluded. As a result, participation becomes partially dependent on the ability to interpret and align with implicit system expectations, rather than solely on the content or quality of the work.

These findings have broader implications for the narrative of open science. While access to scientific content has expanded significantly, access to authorship and participation remains uneven. Quiet exclusion challenges the assumption that openness at the level of access to knowledge implies openness at the level of contribution.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. The analysis relies in part on case-based observations and qualitative evidence, which may not capture the full variability of platform behaviors. Online reports are subject to selection bias and may overrepresent more salient or negative experiences. In addition, platform-specific policies and workflows vary, limiting the direct generalization of individual cases across systems.

Future research could extend this work through systematic measurement of response times, validation outcomes, and access probabilities across different researcher profiles, including variations in affiliation, email domain, and publication history. Controlled experimental designs, such as standardized submission attempts with manipulated identity signals, could help quantify the influence of initial legitimacy cues on access. Further investigation into platform governance, moderation practices, and support responsiveness would also contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of these mechanisms.

In conclusion, a system does not need to reject in order to exclude; it only needs to fail to complete the process. Quiet exclusion is not the absence of interaction, but interaction without state transition. No rejection, no decision, only removal, silence, and loss of access. Many independent researchers assume their work is too poor to deserve publication, when in reality it was never scientifically evaluated. While it is understandable that platforms cannot evaluate all submissions, this limitation should be explicitly stated, so that silence is not internalized as a judgment of quality.

Key points

Open systems can produce exclusion without decisions

Legitimacy signals act as hidden filters

Non-response functions as scalable exclusion

Independent researchers face cumulative process friction

References

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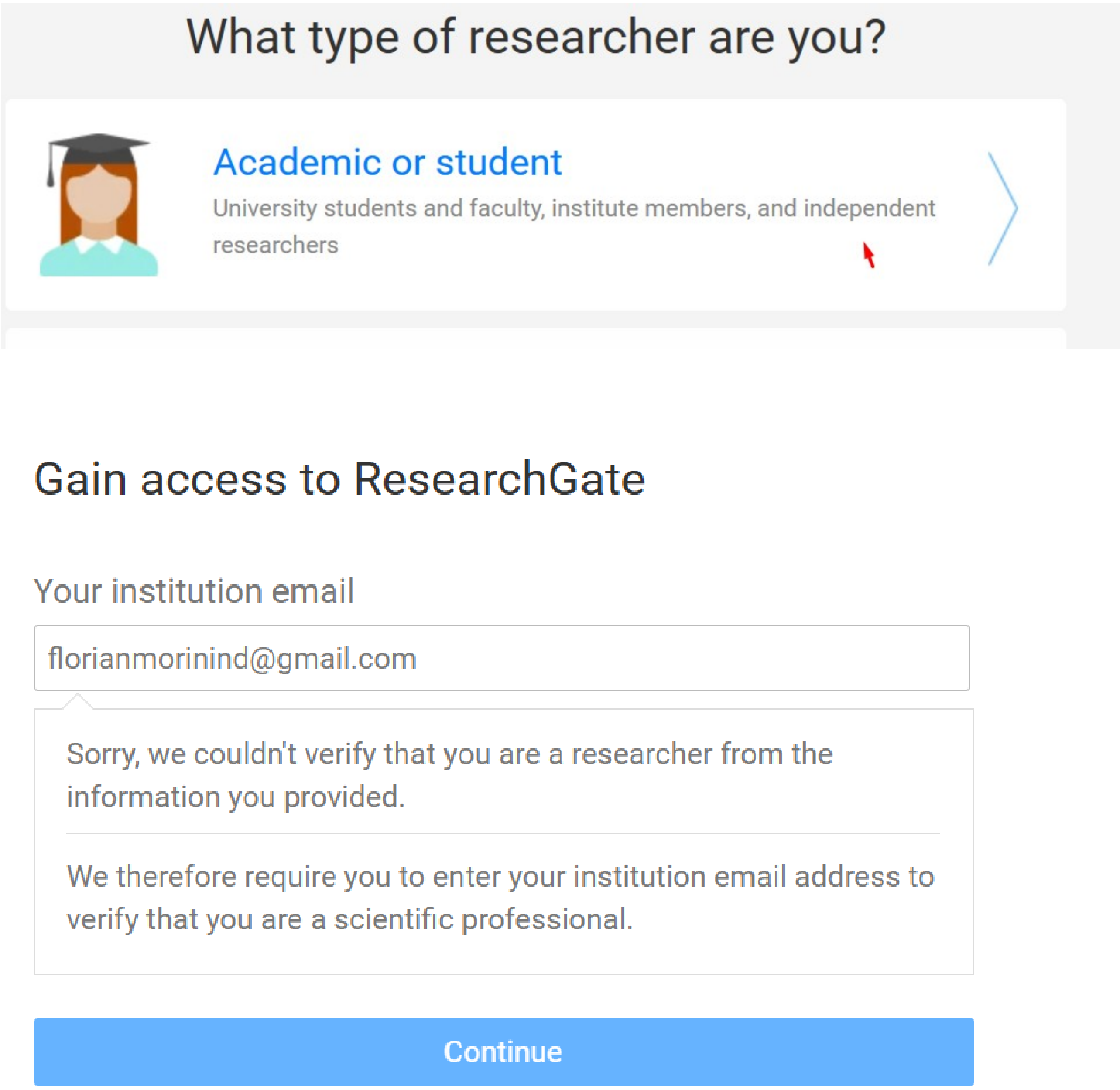
Appendix 1



Appendix Figure A. Screenshot showing access restriction on ResearchGate. The platform rejects a personal email address and requires an institutional affiliation to verify researcher status, preventing account validation despite provided information.

Appendix 2

Independent Research Documentation

Case Record Archive

Zenodo Account Restriction – Documented Case

Author: Florian Morin

Version: 1.0

Date: March 2026

Summary

This document provides a structured record of a Zenodo account restriction, including a timeline of events, a description of uploaded content, and a clarification request. The objective is to document the sequence of interactions and identify potential factors contributing to the restriction.

Context

The uploads are part of an independent research corpus focused on joy mechanisms and evaluative load (Z framework). The materials consist of structured documents intended for open dissemination.

Timeline

[December 2025] – Initial uploads

[January] – Additional uploads (multiple entries and versions)

[February, 20] – Account restriction and content removal

[February, 20] – Support contacted

+5 weeks – No response received

Nature of Content

The uploaded materials consist of structured documents including titles, abstracts, and references.

Each entry is associated with distinct identifiers (titles, dates, DOIs).

Multiple documents and versions were uploaded within a relatively short timeframe.

Observed Outcome

The account was restricted and uploaded records were removed. The removal notice indicated:

Reason: Spam

Action: Automatic system removal

Additional outcome: User account blocked

Metadata retained for archival purposes

No detailed justification or actionable feedback was provided.

Potential Misclassification

The frequency and structure of uploads, including multiple documents and versions submitted within a limited timeframe, may resemble automated or bulk submission patterns.
This similarity may have contributed to automated classification as spam.

Request for Clarification

A request for clarification and review was submitted to Zenodo support.
At the time of writing, no response has been received after four weeks.
Clarification is requested regarding:
The specific criteria used for classification
Whether the restriction can be reviewed
The possibility of restoring access to the removed records

List of Upload with Title, Date and DOI

Transient Suppression of ACC Monitoring Enables High-Salience Positive Affect
24/12/2025
DOI Not available

Affective Collapse Under Causal Closure
January 2026
10.5281/zenodo.18537408

Ease: Evaluation kills entry, not the state: a threshold model of ease
January 2026
10.5281/zenodo.18224573

Regime-Preserving Methods for Studying Children's Engagement.pdf
January 2026
DOI10.5281/zenodo.18235196

Ease Open-State Questionnaire (EOSQ,Draft): What the Open State Feels Like
February 2026
10.5281/zenodo.18654831

Lock-in under suspended optimization J
January 2026
DOI Not available

Positive Affect Contingent On Suspended Optimization
January 2026
DOI Not available

Positive Affect as Suspension of Optimization
January 2026
Not available

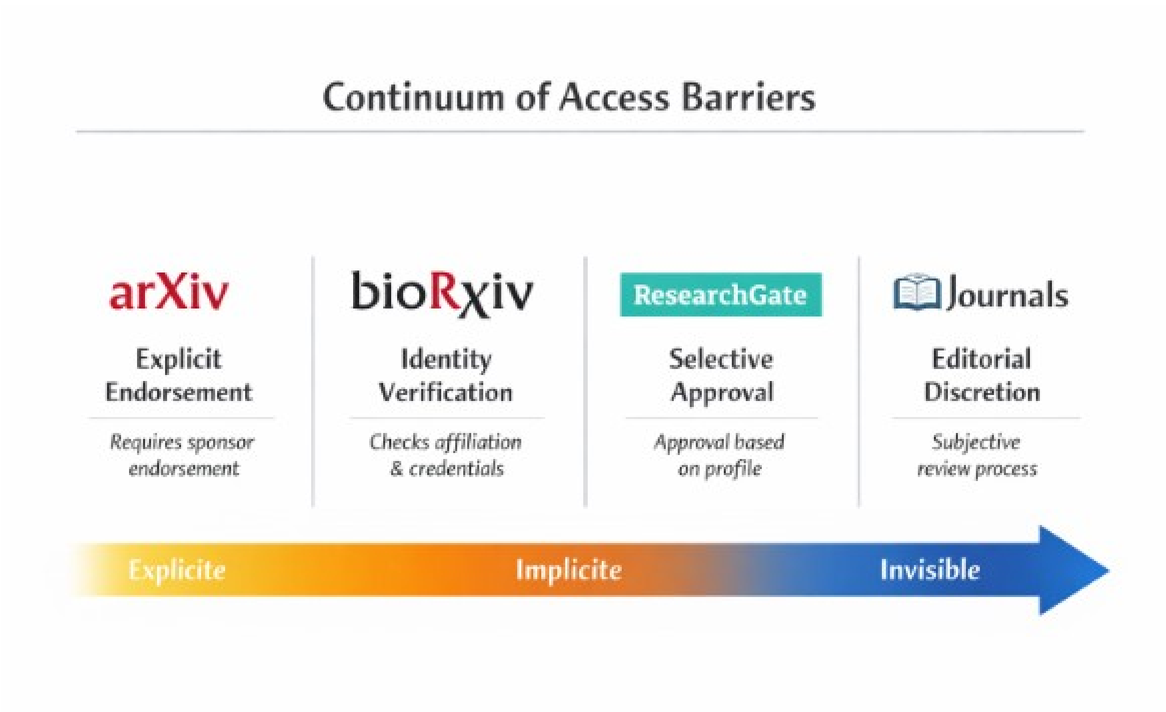
Some entries could not be fully reconstructed due to limited access following account restriction.

A general description of the research corpus is available online (FAQ format), providing additional context on the nature and structure of the uploaded materials:
https://florianmorin.com/assets/pdf/Ease-Framework.pdf

Notes

This document is intended as a factual record of events and does not assume intent or error. It aims to support analysis of access processes and potential classification mechanisms in open science platforms.

Appendix 3



Appendix Figure B. Continuum of access barriers across scientific platforms. Continuum of access barriers across scientific platforms, from explicit requirements (e.g., endorsement or credential checks) to increasingly implicit and opaque forms of selection, culminating in editorial discretion.

Appendix 4: Typology of Access Disruption Mechanisms in Scientific Platforms

These mechanisms do not operate in isolation but may combine, producing compounded forms of access failure. This typology is not intended as an exhaustive classification of platform behaviors, but as a minimal analytical framework to distinguish structurally different modes of access disruption observed across cases.

1. Pure Technical Blocking (Network-Level Restriction)
Description

Access to the platform is denied through automated security systems (e.g., “403 Forbidden – unusual traffic”).
Characteristics
Triggered by IP, traffic patterns, or automated classification
No reference to account status or content
Framed as temporary and correctable
Redirected to support
Underlying mechanism

→ Classification noise + precautionary filtering
Effect on access model
Entry = 0
Progression = not reachable
Completion = undefined
Key property

No explicit exclusion, but total functional inaccessibility.
2. Pure Account-Level Disruption (Administrative / Moderation Action)
Description

The user account is restricted, suspended, or removed.

Characteristics
May or may not be explained
Can involve content removal

Access to platform may remain technically possible
Attribution remains partially visible (account status)
Underlying mechanism

→ Administrative decision (explicit or opaque)
Effect on access model
Entry = conditional or blocked (account-dependent)
Progression = halted
Completion = terminated
Key property

There is at least a theoretical locus of decision, even if unclear.

3. Compound Blocking (Network + Account Interaction)

Description

This appendix outlines a minimal typology of access disruption mechanisms observed across scientific platforms. The objective is not to provide an exhaustive classification, but to distinguish structurally different modes through which access may fail.
A1. Technical Blocking (Network-Level Restriction)
Technical blocking occurs when access is denied through automated security systems, such as traffic classification or IP-based filtering. These mechanisms operate independently of account status or content evaluation.
They are typically presented as temporary or correctable issues, often accompanied by generic messages (e.g., unusual traffic detection) and redirection to support channels.
In such cases, entry is effectively blocked, while progression and completion remain undefined due to the inability to access the system.

A2. Account-Level Disruption (Administrative Action)

Account-level disruption refers to restrictions applied directly to a user account, including suspension, deletion, or limited functionality.
These actions may be partially visible, but often lack detailed justification or clear resolution pathways. While technical access to the platform may remain possible, the ability to progress through submission or evaluation processes is halted.
Here, entry may remain conditionally possible, but progression is interrupted and completion cannot be reached.

A3. Compound Blocking (Interaction of Independent Systems)

Compound blocking arises when multiple independent systems interact, typically combining account-related issues with network-level restrictions.
In reported cases, users encounter account anomalies and, upon attempting to resolve them, face additional access barriers such as automated traffic blocking. This results in the inability to access both the platform and its support interfaces.
In this configuration, all components of access fail simultaneously: entry is blocked, progression is inaccessible, and completion is unreachable.
A defining feature of compound blocking is attribution collapse. Users cannot determine whether the barrier results from technical error, automated filtering, or administrative action.

Note
Access is defined in the main text as a multiplicative process:
Entry × Progression × Completion × Persistence
Failure at any stage results in effective exclusion, even in the absence of explicit rejection.